



Mastering Observability

ADVISORY · STRATEGY · PRACTICE

COMPANION WORKBOOK · METRICS & MAYHEM

The Signal Audit: thirty minutes, one incident, yours.

A working companion to Metrics & Mayhem. Five short audits of your own last incident, and the ninety-day plan that comes out of them.

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FREE COMPANION WORKBOOK · THE ONLY NUMBERS YOU ADD ARE YOUR OWN · SOURCES ARE CHAPTERS 5, 6, 8 AND 11 AND APPENDICES B AND C OF THE BOOK

One honest reconstruction of your own last incident.

This is not a culture survey. It is one honest reconstruction of your own last incident, done by you, before you ask anyone else to do it.

Five short audits and a plan. Each audit takes your most recent real Sev1 or Sev2 and finds the thing your tooling did not capture: the hunch that stayed unsaid, the blame in the first five minutes, the capability you paid for and did not build, the behaviour you reward without meaning to. The plan at the end turns what you found into ninety days.

Do it on the last real incident. Not a hypothetical. Write the answers down; a thought you do not write down is a thought you get to pretend you had.

02 Your real time to truth goes unmeasured

The gap between the thought and the words is one no dashboard shows.

03 The first five minutes show your culture

Whether the bridge goes looking for a cause or for a person.

04 Capability lives in a few heads

Count who could investigate a novel incident on your most critical service alone.

05 What gets recognised repeats

Visible saves get thanked; quiet prevention gets nothing unless you name it.

06 Findings change nothing without names

Five names and dates turn the audits into a quarter's plan.

01
The quick read

02 + 03
Silence, blame

04
Capability

05
Recognition

06
Ninety days

HOW THIS WAS SOURCED

Chapters 5, 6, 8 and 11 and Appendices B and C of Metrics & Mayhem, and the author's own experience, with details changed so no organisation can be identified. No vendor surveys. The only numbers you add are your own.

01

PART ONE • THE AUDITS

The incident did more than the tools saw

Five audits, in the order the failure happens: the honest read on the whole, then the silence, the first five minutes, the capability, and the behaviour you reward.

01 Your last bridge was quieter than you think

Thursday, 14:22. A junior engineer sees a payment completion rate drop from 99.2% to 97.8%. She checks the deployment log. A configuration change shipped twenty minutes ago. She thinks it might be the cause. She says nothing on the incident channel for eleven minutes, because the last time she flagged something, the VP of Engineering asked "who approved this?" in a tone that made everyone go quiet.

That scene opens Chapter 6 of the book. Before you audit the parts, get an honest read on the whole.

THE QUICK READ • ONE WORD EACH, FIRST INSTINCT

- 01 On your last incident, could the person nearest the cause say so without it costing them? Yes or no.

- 02 Did your first five minutes go looking for a cause, or for a person? Cause or person.

- 03 Do the engineers you pay to use your observability tools actually use them, or have three people become the ones who always investigate? Used or hoarded.

- 04 When someone surfaces a problem early and is right, does anything good visibly happen to them? Yes or no.

- 05 If the same incident happened next week, would your team be faster? Yes or no.

What this tells you

Count your "no", "person", and "hoarded" answers. Each one is a section of this workbook you should not skip. Zero of them and you are the rare exception; do the audits anyway, because the gap between what a leader believes about their culture and what their last bridge did is almost always wider than the leader thinks.

02 Every incident has a record nobody wrote down

Every incident has two records. The one your tooling captured, and the one that lived in someone's head and never got said.

FROM THE FIELD

I was running the technical side of a call that went on for the best part of three days. We suspected early that the fault sat in the one component we could not see into: third-party infrastructure someone else ran for us, a black box to everyone on the call. I had been asking for data out of it for months. When I did say it, late, it did not land. Senior people on the call, several teams each looking at their own patch, and I had nothing to put behind what I thought.

In the end we got agreement to put an agent on it. Under an hour from that decision to data flowing, and we could see it. The best part of three days blind, under an hour sighted. That is the day observability stopped being a line item to the people upstairs.

Source: author's experience; details changed, durations rounded

This audit finds the silence in your own last incident.

THE AUDIT

- 01 Name the incident. One line: what broke, and when.

- 02 Write down the moment someone first suspected the real cause. Not when it was confirmed. When someone first had the thought.

- 03 Name who had that thought. If it was not the person who eventually said it out loud, write both names.

- 04 Write down how long sat between the thought and the words. Minutes. Best honest estimate.

- 05 Write down why the gap existed. Not "we were busy". The actual reason: who was on the call, what saying it would have cost, what happened last time someone spoke early.

- 06 Score it. On your last incident, was surfacing a hunch early safe, costly, or career-limiting? One word.

What you just found

If steps 4 and 5 were uncomfortable to write, that is the finding. The gap between the thought and the words is your real time to truth, and no dashboard measures it. If you could not answer step 3, that is worse: the knowledge was so quiet you cannot even name who held it.

On Monday. Take the reason from step 5 and change one thing about your next bridge so that reason is weaker. Not a policy. One thing. If the reason was "the last person who spoke early got blamed", the one thing is that you speak your own hunch first, out loud, wrong or right, so the room watches nothing bad happen to the person who did.

SECTION 03 • THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

03 Blame-aware, not blameless-in-name

Most engineering leaders will tell you their incident process is blameless. Most are wrong, and the place to prove it is the first five minutes of the bridge.

"Blameless" became the word everyone learned and almost nobody practised. It got printed on the runbook and contradicted on the call. The distinction that matters: blameless does not mean consequence-free, and pretending it does is its own dishonesty. What you want is what J. Paul Reed calls blame-aware. A room that can say "this change caused it" without the person who made the change hearing "this is your fault".

I have run bridges where the first question was "what changed?" and bridges where it was "who deployed?". They sound almost the same. They produce completely different rooms.

THE AUDIT • SAME INCIDENT, IF YOU CAN

- 01** Write down the actual first sentence spoken once the incident was confirmed. The real words, not the tidy version.

- 02** Mark it: was that sentence looking for a CAUSE or a PERSON? One word.

- 03** Name who spoke first, and their role. The person running the call, the most senior in the room, or the person nearest the blast radius?

- 04** Write down what happened to the person whose change was involved. Not the incident outcome. What happened to THEM, in the room and after.

- 05** If the same person caused the same incident next week, would they surface it faster or slower? One word.

- 06** Write down one sentence your process SAYS about blame, and one thing your last bridge DID.

What you just found

If step 2 said "person" and step 5 said "slower", you do not have a blameless culture. You have a blameless poster. If step 5 said "faster", write down why, because whatever you did is the thing to keep doing, and most leaders cannot name it.

On Monday. Decide the first sentence you want spoken on your next bridge, and be the one who says it. If your instinct was "who deployed", the replacement is "what changed, and let us get the person who made the change into the room, because they will know fastest". Same information. Opposite signal. You cannot mandate psychological safety. You can only demonstrate it, five minutes at a time.

SECTION 04 • CAPABILITY

04 Capability beats certification

You signed a large platform contract. The vendor ran a two-day course. Everyone got certificates. Six months later, three engineers use the tool properly and the rest went back to grepping logs.

Training is not capability. Training teaches the interface. Capability is knowing which question to ask when the payment success rate drops at two in the morning, and no certificate teaches that. Capability is built by connecting engineers to outcomes under real conditions: pairing on production data, incident reviews as learning, measuring practice instead of platform.

I have watched organisations send two hundred engineers through a course and still have the same five people do all the investigation. The certificate taught the tool. It did not teach the thinking.

THE AUDIT

- 01 Name your most business-critical service. Now name every engineer who could investigate a novel incident on it alone, at three in the morning. Count them.

- 02 If that number is under three, write down what happens when those people are on leave at the same time.

- 03 Write down how many engineers created or modified a dashboard, or defined an SLO they actually review, in the last thirty days. If you cannot get the number at all, that is the finding.

- 04 Take one recent incident review. Write down whether it ended in a new alert, or a new question your team can now ask of the system.

- 05 Name one engineer who can operate the platform but cannot yet connect a signal to a business outcome. Write down the one pairing or review that would move them.

What you just found

Capability lives in a small number of heads, and you can now count them. You cannot post your way out of this gap. It closes in the work, incident by incident, over months. The number in step 1 is the one to grow, and step 5 is where you start.

SECTION 04 · THE 30-DAY TRACKER

Count the thinking, not the seats

For the next thirty days, track one number: how many different engineers touched the observability stack in a way that required thinking, not just looking. A dashboard built. An SLO defined. A question instrumented in a review. Write the count at the end of each week.

WEEK	ENGINEERS WHO DID THE THINKING WORK	WHAT THEY DID
Week 1		
Week 2		
Week 3		
Week 4		

Four numbers. If they do not move, the practice is not embedded yet, and no course will embed it.

On Monday. Take the engineer from step 5 and pair them, this week, with the outcome rather than the service. Not "own the checkout service". "Own explaining the payment completion rate." When accountability includes a business outcome, people start asking different questions of their data.

05 What gets recognised repeats

People do more of what gets noticed. That is not motivational; it is just true, and most observability cultures reward exactly the wrong thing without meaning to.

The engineer who fights a visible three-hour fire gets thanked in the channel. The engineer whose quiet instrumentation meant the fire never started gets nothing, because you cannot see the incident that did not happen. The behaviour you want, surfacing problems early and building the boring foundation, is the behaviour that is hardest to see, which means it is the behaviour you have to go looking for on purpose.

Reward firefighting and you will grow firefighters.

THE AUDIT

- 01 Write down the last three people you publicly recognised in an engineering context, and what for. Be honest: was it a visible save, or a quiet prevention?

- 02 Write down the name of one person whose work stopped an incident happening in the last quarter. If you cannot name one, that is not because it did not happen. It is because you cannot see it.

- 03 Take the engineer from the silence audit who surfaced a hunch early. Write down what happened to them next. Recognition, silence, or a reputation.

- 04 Write down what your last promotion or public thank-you actually rewarded. Then write down whether that is the behaviour you would want every engineer to copy.

What you just found

Line up your answers. If step 1 is all visible saves and step 2 is blank, you are training your best engineers to let fires start so they can be seen putting them out. What you recognise, you get more of. The prevention you cannot see is the prevention you have to name on purpose, or it stops.

On Monday. Find one quiet prevention from the last quarter, the boring instrumentation or the early flag that a fire never followed, and recognise it publicly, by name, specifically. Not "great work team". "This did not become an incident because X did Y." Do it once and people notice; do it as a habit and the culture shifts.

02

PART TWO • THE PLAN

Five findings become ninety days

You have five findings now. An honest first read, a silence, a first sentence, a capability count, a recognition gap, and the reasons behind each. Findings change nothing. A name next to a commitment changes something.

06 Findings change nothing until a name is attached

The book's Appendix B is a printable 90-Day Transformation Scorecard, and Appendix C is a three-layer ownership template. Use them. The act of writing a name next to a commitment, by hand, is the point. What follows sequences your own findings into them.

This week: the three conversations

Thirty minutes. One question each. This week.

THE THREE CONVERSATIONS • WRITE DOWN EACH ANSWER

- 01 Ask your VP of Engineering: "What is our most critical business outcome, and can we explain it end to end?"

- 02 Ask your CFO: "What is our total observability spend, across every cost centre?"

- 03 Ask your most senior on-call engineer: "When you get the call, how long until you understand the business impact, not just the technical symptom?"

The gaps between what you expect and what you hear are your starting line.

One quarter needs five names

WRITE THE NAME, THEN THE DATE

- 01** Name one outcome. From the VP conversation, the single business outcome you will make your team able to explain and own. One. Not a portfolio.
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- 02** Name one owner. Not the team. The person who owns that outcome end to end. This is Appendix C.
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- 03** Name one thing you will make safe. From the silence and first-five-minutes audits, the one change to your bridge that makes early truth cheaper. Commit a date.
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- 04** Name one capability you will build. From the capability audit, the one pairing or review cadence you will run for a quarter, and who tracks the number.
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- 05** Name one behaviour you will reward. From the recognition audit, the quiet prevention you will recognise publicly, and how often.
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COMMITMENT	NAME	DATE	HOW YOU WILL KNOW
Outcome			
Owner			
Made safe			
Capability			
Recognised			

Five names. One quarter. Put them in the Appendix B scorecard, by hand, with dates, and review it in ninety days against the numbers your own audits gave you.

The honest part

This is fact. If you do not do the foundations properly, and you do not believe in standards and basic practice, you will not get this right. Not with a better tool, not with a bigger team. Good practice across the stack: cut the noise, make sure an alert reaches the person who can act on it, and watch the things you do not own as carefully as the things you do. We did not do that, and it cost us the best part of three days. You must do it.

None of this is a tool you can buy. Every line is a decision only you can make and only you can hold. That is why it was skipped: it is harder than a purchase order and it does not show up on a vendor's slide. It is also the only thing that has ever moved the numbers.

IF YOU WANT TO RUN THIS ACROSS AN ORGANISATION

Four steps turn the audit into a quarter

- 01 **Do the five audits on one real incident.** Your last Sev1 or Sev2, not a hypothetical, written down.
- 02 **Have the three conversations this week.** VP of Engineering, CFO, most senior on-call engineer.
- 03 **Write five names into the scorecard.** One outcome, one owner, one thing made safe, one capability, one behaviour rewarded.
- 04 **Review it in ninety days** against the numbers your own audits gave you.

Running this across a whole engineering function, so early truth is safe by default and not by luck, so capability is grown in the work, not bought in a course, and so the right behaviour is the one that gets seen, is a programme, not a poster.

THE ONE ASK

Book a free 30-minute review.

Bring the audit you have just done. Thirty minutes with me on your last incident, free, and you leave knowing whether this needs a programme or just a Monday.

calendar.app.google/y2wSmwhGrkf8r5Xv5